

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN KIRIBATI

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

This guide must begin honestly, because Kiribati is a poor, remote, low-lying atoll nation where the hardest destructive decisions are driven not by greed but by genuine need, and there is no community victory to point to. Kiribati is a scattered republic of atolls in the central Pacific, home to around 120,000 people, with an ocean territory larger than India and more tuna caught in its waters, year after year, than in those of any other nation on earth — and with fishing licences supplying more than seventy percent of the government's revenue. In that context, its most consequential recent decision was to reverse one of its own greatest conservation achievements: in late 2021 the Cabinet decided to reopen the **Phoenix Islands Protected Area** — some four hundred thousand square kilometres of ocean, an area the size of California, a UNESCO World Heritage site and once one of the largest marine reserves on earth — to commercial fishing, because the fund meant to replace the lost revenue had raised only a fraction of what was promised, and a poor nation, in the end, could not afford to keep so much of its ocean closed to the fishing that sustains it. The historical devastation of **Banaba**, whose phosphate was strip-mined until the island was left barely habitable and its people resettled far away, is a warning of what extraction can do. This guide will not pretend that opposing such decisions is simple, or that the community has prevailed; it has not.

A community in Kiribati defending its ocean and reefs works with real tools, but the honest lesson of the Phoenix Islands is that conservation survives only if it is made to serve the people. The distinctive lever is the **maneaba** — the ancient meeting-house of collective decision-making at the heart of I-Kiribati governance, a community's first and most legitimate forum, giving the whole community a voice. The **elected Maneaba ni Maungatabu**, the national Assembly, must approve major measures and is answerable to the people and the islands; protest, petition, and democratic participation are lawful. **UNESCO's World Heritage status and the international conservation partners** can reward, fund, and — crucially — make protection pay, so a poor nation need not choose between its ocean and its revenue. The **Pacific regional and fisheries bodies** give a small nation collective strength, and major harmful projects must reckon with **environmental assessment**. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The obstacle here is often genuine poverty and genuine sovereignty, not villainy: the government reopened the reserve because a low-income nation depends on fishing revenue and the conservation funding fell short — a real dilemma, not a scandal — and it rightly resists having conservation imposed from outside as a neo-colonial demand. Banaba warns what extraction can do, but also reminds that a poor island's resources are often all it has. And there is no community victory to point to. So the honest path is never to lecture a struggling nation but to help make protection pay and serve the people — through the maneaba, the democracy, and the partners who can fund and reward the defence of the ocean — and the honest prize is the ocean and reefs defended in a way the people can afford, not a conservation imposed that will not last.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You win here not by lecturing a poor, sovereign nation to close its ocean, but by making protection serve its people. Bring the matter to the maneaba, the community's own legitimate forum; work the democratic Assembly; and above all use the World Heritage system and the conservation partners to fund and reward protection, so a poor nation need not choose between its ocean and its revenue. The lesson of the Phoenix

Islands is that conservation that does not meet the people's needs will not last.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Kiribati is a poor, sovereign atoll democracy, and honesty about that is the first discipline. The hardest decisions are driven by genuine need, not greed: the reserve was reopened because a low-income nation depends on fishing revenue and the conservation funding fell short — a real dilemma, and one no outsider should lecture about. Banaba warns of extraction's cost, but a poor island's resources are often all it has. So the realistic aim is the ocean and reefs defended in a way the people can afford — through the maneaba, the democracy, and the partners who can make protection pay — not a conservation imposed from outside that will not hold.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

A Kiribati decision runs through custom, democracy, and international partnership. The **maneaba**, the traditional meeting-house, is the community's own forum of collective decision. The **Cabinet and the elected Maneaba ni Maungatabu** decide the licences, the reserves, and the major measures, answerable to the people. The **World Heritage system and the international conservation partners** can fund and reward protection. And the **Pacific regional and fisheries bodies** give a small nation collective strength. Map who decides — and who can make protection pay — before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A decision — to reopen a reserve, license a harmful fishery, permit an extraction — moves through the Cabinet and Assembly, and, for the community, through the maneaba. You enter through the maneaba first, the community's most legitimate forum; then the democratic Assembly; and, crucially, through the international partners who can fund and reward protection, so the decision need not pit the ocean against the revenue. For a harmful extraction or development, the entry point is also the environmental assessment.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the revenue: how much a nation depends on fishing licences, and whether protection can be made to pay as well. Follow the decision: what the Cabinet and Assembly propose, and how the maneaba can shape it. Follow the partners: which World Heritage, conservation, and regional bodies can fund and reward the defence of the ocean. The leverage lies in the maneaba, the democracy, and the partners who can make protection pay.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

The watchers here are the maneaba and the community's own collective governance, the elected Assembly, the World Heritage system and the conservation partners, and the Pacific regional and fisheries bodies. These are the channels a case engages — not to impose conservation, but to make protection serve and pay the people.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Kiribati effort easily reverses a need-driven decision, and honesty requires saying so — the Phoenix Islands reopening was a real dilemma, not a scandal, and the community has not prevailed. What the tools

can deliver is the ocean and reefs defended in a way the people can afford. The single most decisive move is **making protection pay through the World Heritage system and the conservation partners**, because a poor nation will keep its ocean closed only if doing so serves its people, and because the maneaba and the democracy give the community its most legitimate voice. The maneaba is the community's forum; the democracy the decision; the partners who fund and reward protection the distinctive lever. The realistic prize is protection made affordable and lasting, not imposed from outside.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the reserve reopened, the fishery over-licensed, the reef or lagoon threatened, the extraction proposed. **What need drives it?** — the revenue a poor nation depends on. **Can protection be made to pay?** — the World Heritage, conservation, or regional funding that could replace it. **Which forum reaches it?** — the maneaba first, then the Assembly. **Is it an extraction?** — where the environmental assessment and the Banaba warning apply. Pick the fight where protection can be made affordable and the maneaba and partners give the clearest path.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, honestly. **Layer one: the harm and the need** — the ocean, reef, or reserve at stake, and the genuine revenue need behind the decision, stated fairly. **Layer two: the way to make protection pay** — the World Heritage and conservation funding, the regional support, that could let the nation protect without losing what it depends on. **Layer three: the forum and the partners** — the maneaba and Assembly to engage, and the partners to bring in. A case that respects the nation's need and shows how protection can be made to pay — not one that lectures a poor country to sacrifice — is the one that can actually hold.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the ocean, reef, or reserve at stake, the science of its value, the threat. Gather the **need record**: the revenue the nation depends on, stated fairly and without judgement. Gather the **funding record**: the World Heritage, conservation, and regional support that could make protection pay. Gather the **forum record**: the maneaba, the Assembly, the partners. Gather the **honesty discipline**: confirm the case respects the nation's sovereignty and need, and offers protection that serves the people.

STEP 3: BUILDING COMMUNITY AND INTERNATIONAL SUPPORT

The coalition here begins in the community's own forum. Build with the **maneaba and the whole community**, whose collective voice is the most legitimate; the **elected representatives** answerable to the islands; the **World Heritage and conservation partners** who can fund and reward protection; and the **Pacific regional and fisheries bodies**. Frame the effort around making protection serve and pay the people, never around imposing conservation on a struggling nation; respect the sovereignty and the need; and bring the partners in as funders of a shared future, not as outside demanders.

STEP 4: THE MANEABA, THE DEMOCRACY & MAKING PROTECTION PAY — DEFENDING THE OCEAN

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained by genuine poverty and sovereignty, so the prize is protection made affordable and lasting.

The Maneaba and the Democracy

The **maneaba** — the meeting-house of collective decision — is the community's first and most legitimate forum, and the **elected Maneaba ni Maungatabu** decides the major measures. Bring the matter to the maneaba, win the community's collective voice, and carry it to the democratic Assembly.

Making Protection Pay

The distinctive lever is making protection pay: the **World Heritage system and the international conservation partners** can fund and reward the defence of the ocean, so a poor nation need not choose between its reserve and its revenue. This is the lesson of the Phoenix Islands — conservation that does not meet the people's needs will not last, so make it serve them.

The Regional Bodies and the Assessment

The **Pacific regional and fisheries bodies** give a small nation collective strength, and major extractions must reckon with **environmental assessment** — the Banaba warning made concrete. Pursued together — the maneaba and democracy, the funding that makes protection pay, and the regional strength — these levers defend the ocean in a way the people can afford.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the maneaba:** here is our ocean and our future, and the collective voice to shape it. **For the Assembly:** here is a way to protect that serves the people, not one that sacrifices them. **For the World Heritage and conservation partners:** here is a globally significant ocean, and the funding needed to make its protection pay. **For the regional bodies:** here is a small nation's collective strength. **For an extraction:** here is the Banaba warning and the assessment it demands. **The golden rule:** respect the nation's need and sovereignty, show how protection can be made to pay, and work through the maneaba, the democracy, and the partners — never lecture a struggling nation.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media matters, handled with respect for a poor, sovereign nation. Frame the story around **making protection serve the people:** a globally significant ocean, a poor nation's real dilemma, and the way to defend the reefs and reserves that also meets the people's needs — never as blame on a struggling country. Carry it through the Pacific and international conservation outlets and the partners who can fund protection. A few cautions: never lecture or shame the nation; respect the sovereignty and the need; frame it around protection that pays; and let the ocean's value and the funding solution carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message respectful of the nation's need and sovereignty, and framed around making protection pay.

8A — To the maneaba: bring the matter of the ocean and the community's collective voice to the meeting-house.

8B — To a member of the Assembly: set out a way to protect the ocean that serves the people, not one that sacrifices them.

8C — To a World Heritage or conservation partner: present the globally significant ocean and the funding needed to make its protection pay.

8D — To a regional or fisheries body: describe the shared stake and ask for collective strength.

8E — On making protection pay: set out the funding and rewards that could replace the revenue a reserve would cost.

8F — On an extraction: invoke the Banaba warning and request the environmental assessment.

8G — To the community: set out the ocean, the need, and the way protection can serve the people, and organise through the maneaba.

8H — To the international public: summarise the ocean and the dilemma, and ask for the funding that makes protection pay — never lecturing the nation.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: bring the matter to the maneaba; document the ocean at stake and the revenue need fairly; identify the conservation partners who could make protection pay. **The fastest-moving levers:** the maneaba, the democratic Assembly, and the funding that makes protection pay. **Emergency action:** if a reserve or fishery decision is imminent, the maneaba's collective voice and the conservation partners who can fund an alternative are the sharpest handles. Throughout, respect the nation's need and never lecture a struggling country.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted not by villainy but by genuine poverty and sovereignty: a poor nation depends on fishing revenue, and conservation funding has fallen short. Recognise it and adjust the aim — not a conservation imposed, but protection made to serve and pay the people. Lean on the levers that fit that reality: the maneaba's legitimate voice, the democracy, and above all the partners who can make protection pay. And accept the honest limits — the need is real, the sovereignty must be respected, and the community has not prevailed — while still defending the ocean in a way the people can afford.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Here the usual obstacle is genuine need, not corruption, and honesty requires saying so. But where a decision serves private interests rather than the people — a licence steered to insiders, an extraction that enriches a few while devastating an island as Banaba was — respond through the legitimate channels: the maneaba, the democratic Assembly, the World Heritage and conservation partners, the regional bodies, and the environmental assessment. **On safety:** Kiribati is a peaceful, rule-of-law atoll democracy; the risks here are not physical but the risk of lecturing or shaming a poor, sovereign nation. So the work is open and democratic, but always respectful of the nation's need and sovereignty, and framed around protection that serves and pays the people.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, respectfully. The documented ocean and the fairly-stated need feed the maneaba, the Assembly, and the funding case at once; the community organises through its own forum; the partners are brought in to make protection pay; any media respects the nation throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, bring the matter to the maneaba and document the ocean and the need; **months two to six**, work the Assembly and engage the World Heritage and conservation partners to fund protection; **beyond**, secure the protection that serves the people, and make it last. The core discipline: maneaba-grounded, sovereignty-respecting, and built on making protection pay.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Kiribati is among the most honest and difficult grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a need-driven decision can simply be reversed, or that the community has prevailed, or that a poor, sovereign nation should be lectured to sacrifice the revenue it depends on — none of that is true, and the Phoenix Islands reopening was a real dilemma, not a scandal. What it claims is narrower and real: that the maneaba, the ancient meeting-house of collective decision, gives the community its most legitimate voice; that the elected Assembly decides the major measures; that the World Heritage system and the conservation partners can fund and reward protection, so a poor nation need not choose between its ocean and its revenue; and that the Pacific regional bodies give a small nation collective strength. The levers are constrained by genuine poverty and sovereignty, and the prize is the ocean and reefs defended in a way the people can afford — not a conservation imposed that will not last. For a poor, sovereign atoll democracy, that respectful work — grounded in the maneaba, the democracy, and the making of protection pay — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only one that can hold, because the lesson of the Phoenix Islands is precisely that conservation which does not serve the people will not endure.